

New Testament Manuscripts

Key Papyri — Earliest Witnesses			
MS	Date	Contents	Significance
P52	~125 CE	John 18:31–33, 37–38	Oldest known NT fragment; about the size of a credit card; confirms John's early circulation in Egypt
P75	~175–225 CE	Luke and John	Earliest witness to Luke; text is extremely close to Codex Vaticanus (see below), thus proving the Alexandrian text type is ancient
P46	~200 CE	Paul's letters + Hebrews	Earliest Pauline collection, but has no pastorals
P66	~200 CE	Most of John 1-14	Mixture of Alexandrian and Western text types
P45	~250 CE	Portions of all four gospels + Acts	Earliest manuscript with all four gospels
P47	~250 CE	Revelation 9–17	One of the earliest Revelation witnesses
P72	~300 CE	1 & 2 Peter, Jude, and many non-canonical writings	Earliest witness to both Peter and Jude

Major Manuscripts — The Great Uncial Codices				
Siglum	Name	Date	Text Type	Contents & Notes
B (03)	Codex Vaticanus	4th c.	Alexandrian	Generally considered the most important NT manuscript; lacks the pastorals, Philemon, and Revelation; possibly one of Constantine's fifty commissioned bibles
(01) ⲛ	Codex Sinaiticus	4th c.	Alexandrian	The only complete Greek NT in a single ancient manuscript; also includes the Epistle of Barnabas and the Shepherd of Hermas; this and Vaticanus stand far above all others
A (02)	Codex Alexandrinus	5th c.	Mixed	Alexandrian in Paul's letters; Byzantine in the Gospels; also includes 1 & 2 Clement
C (04)	Codex Ephraemi	5th c.	Mixed	A palimpsest — NT text scraped off and overwritten with sermons; original text recovered by using chemical reagents
D (05)	Codex Bezae	5th c.	Western	Greek and Latin side-by-side; contains the gospels and Acts; Acts is approximately 10% longer than in the other major uncials

Significant Textual Variants				
Passage	Reference	Contents/Notes	Manuscript Evidence	Scholarly Consensus
Long ending of Mark	Mark 16:9–20	Describes post-resurrection appearances and ascension to heaven; also, the Great Commission, speaking in tongues, and snake handling; contains many words not found elsewhere in Mark; 16:8 reads "they said nothing to anyone, for they were afraid"	Absent from Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and several early versions; Eusebius and Jerome both noted its absence	Almost certainly a 2nd-century addition
Woman caught in adultery	John 7:53–8:11	Different vocabulary and literary style than the rest of the gospel	Absent from virtually all early Greek manuscripts including P66, P75, Sinaiticus, and Vaticanus; also absent from all early versions	Almost certainly not original; possibly an authentic early oral tradition that was eventually inserted into the text
Johannine Comma	1 John 5:7–8	The only explicit Trinitarian statement in the NT: "the Father, the Word, and the Holy Spirit, and these three are one"; foundational to the KJV-only movement, but Erasmus excluded it from his original Greek text of the NT (then reluctantly included it under pressure)	Absent from all Greek manuscripts before the 14th century; also absent from all early versions and the church fathers	A Latin interpolation that was inserted to provide scriptural support for the Trinitarian doctrine
Jesus' blood-like sweat	Luke 22:43–44	An angel strengthens Jesus at Gethsemane, and his sweat becomes "like great drops of blood"; does not fit well with Luke's portrayal of Jesus as being generally calm and in control	Absent from P75, Vaticanus, Alexandrinus, and several early versions; present in Sinaiticus and many Western manuscripts	Probably not original; may be an early scribal addition from oral tradition